



Sealing bullet wounds

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Hybrid Laptops

dawn of this era of hybrid laptops. With time and continued human ingenuity, the hybrids will evolve into sleeker, more powerful devices, promising to do a lot more than we can ever think of right now. Until then, we have these.

ASUS Transformer Book T100T

When it comes to size and unrestricted ultraportability, look no further than the Transformer Book T100T featured in this comparison. It's a cute little hybrid device which comes with a 10-inch multitouch screen fused to a keyboard through a locking mechanism at its spine with no hinge. The overall build of the two devices isn't bad, it's good, and the detachable screen and keyboard dock are made of decent plastic. And the whole thing is just over 1 kg in weight, fits nicely in a backpack or a large purse, and easy to stow away. However, the locking mechanism that holds the screen and keyboard together isn't the best we've seen in a hybrid device. Also, the button used to release the screen from the keyboard isn't one of the best, and could've been better.

The most important thing about the ASUS Transformer Book T100T is the fact that there are two different parts of the device and full of built-in battery in both of them. This helps, and also shows in our battery test, with the Transformer Book T100T flying past the competition, clocking in a whopping 7 hours in our high-performance benchmark test. This is head and shoulders above all the other hybrid devices we've compared in our test this month. By far, this is the most redeeming aspect of the ASUS Transformer Book T100T, according to us. In every other aspect, this device is

HOW WE TESTED

Initial setup: Since hybrids are largely laptops with the ability to morph into tablets, we largely tested them just like any other laptop we benchmark. All hybrid laptops to be tested are first examined and everything about them is catalogued, including bundled software, accessories, etc. We then completely wipe all data on the laptops and install a copy of the Windows 8.1 Enterprise Edition. Drivers and essential software are installed from the manufacturers' website before running Windows update. This is done to ensure that the laptops don't have any bloatware or trivial apps, only essential drivers that will help the device's hardware to run at optimum performance without any software bottlenecks. Finally, the devices are set to run in performance mode in the BIOS as well as in the power options. After this, the hybrid laptops are ready to go into the grinder of our performance benchmarks.

Performance tests: We conduct a whole series of tests on the devices to measure the impact of every aspect of the system on overall performance – tests that stress the laptop's CPU, RAM, GPU, hard drive, screen, thermals, battery, and more. These tests include industry standard benchmarks including (and not limited to) Futuremark's PCMark 8 and 3D Mark, MAXON Cinebench, and others. We use PCMark 8's Creative test suite to evaluate battery life of each laptop, as well. Results are carefully catalogued. Screen brightness and contrast ratio is measured using the Spyder3 Elite test unit.

A series of subjective testing is also conducted that scores aspects such as a laptop's keyboard, touchpad, palmrest, screen readability, onboard speakers, look and feel, among others. These tests help complete the gamut of objective benchmarks with real-world test scenarios, allowing us to take a fairly homogeneous look at the laptop's overall performance.

The final performance score is arrived at which includes the weighted sum of all the scores catalogued. Weights are assigned based on the perceived importance of the components. For example, since gaming doesn't really matter or all that important on a business laptop, gaming benchmarks and scores from them are of lesser importance here than they would be on a home entertainment or gaming laptop. Stuff like battery life, screen brightness, CPU performance will be of significantly greater importance in a business setup.

Features score: The features present in each Ultrabook are tabulated and given weighted scores depending on perceived importance. For example, dedicated multimedia keys and volume keys are given more weightage than those that are shared with Fn keys.

Design and Usability: The scores for this parameter are largely subjective as they indicate our experience with the device. Items such as quality of the keyboard, responsiveness of the touch-screen, etc. are weighted and scored. In the case of hybrids, we gave devices that had detachable screens slightly higher points compared to devices which had swivelling or rotating screens. Devices that came with a dedicated stylus got higher points, too, because it made interacting with them that much more simpler.

Final score: The final score that we arrive at is the sum of the performance, features and design scores with a 40%, 30% and 30% weightage, respectively. This is not a fixed weightage, and depending on the category of laptops we're testing, these weightages can be different.

A note on winners: The Best Buy laptop is awarded to the device with the best price to performance ratio based on a pre-determined formula. This is the ideal, value for money product in the test. The Best Performer award is awarded to the device with the highest overall performance score. The Editor's Pick award is awarded to the device that the reviewer feels is the best product that offers something extra or unique that none of the other laptops have. The Editor's Pick is an entirely subjective award, the decision for which is based on the reviewer's experience while testing the products.

either average or mediocre, but when it comes to battery life, it impresses like no other.

What else can you expect from a netbook? In all honesty, that's what the ASUS Transformer Book T100T is at the end of the day. Just a glorified netbook with a detachable screen which can be used as

a Windows 8.1 touch-enabled tablet. You can't do a lot with it, if you're considering to buy it as your primary mobility device – just email, working on Microsoft Word, listening to music or watching YouTube videos. That's about it for this one, nothing more that is resource-intensive. And that's

probably the biggest shortfall of the ASUS Transformer Book T100T. But at its price, it's unrealistic to have a high-performing machine anyways, so we can't fault the Transformer Book T100T overmuch.

The ASUS Transformer Book T100T isn't a laptop-tablet hybrid, it's a netbook-tablet